

Nirvan Sutra

CHAPTER 1

The Search for the Self

Who Am I?

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The first chapter of Nirvan Sutra

About this chapter

Chapter 1 of Nirvan Sutra: a simple, practical inquiry into body, mind, experiencer, ego, and witness.

Read slowly; this chapter is meant to be observed in life, not finished in haste.

Contents

First Section - The First Knock of “Who Am I?”

Second Section - Am I the Mind?

Third Section - The Difference Between Witness and Experiencer

Fourth Section - Stabilizing the Understanding in Life

First Section - The First Knock of “Who Am I?”

Introduction: When Does the Journey Begin?

The spiritual journey does not always begin in a temple, an ashram, or a sacred book. Many times it begins with a very ordinary restlessness.

Outwardly, life may look fine. Work is going on. Family is there. People know you. Sometimes money comes, sometimes appreciation comes, and sometimes a dream is also fulfilled. Yet somewhere inside, an emptiness remains. It feels as if something is still missing. Life is moving, but a deeper answer is still waiting.

Many people try to cover this restlessness. One person becomes busier with work. Another searches for the answer in relationships. Someone else escapes into entertainment. Someone creates a new goal. For some time the mind remains occupied, but in a quiet moment, often at night, the same question returns: is this all that life is?

This question is not a sign of weakness. It is a sign of inner honesty. When a human being is no longer satisfied with

merely living, and begins to ask, “Who am I? Why do I suffer? Why does something still feel incomplete?” then the spiritual journey has begun.

This journey is not an escape from the world. It is a return to oneself.

It is like living in your own house for many years and not knowing that there is a quiet room inside where you have never entered. In the same way, we live for years in body, name, work, relationships and thoughts, but we rarely look toward that quiet place within from where all experiences are known.

This chapter begins with a simple question. It looks small, but it reaches the root of life: **Who am I?**

“Who Am I?” - Ancient, Yet Always New

The question “Who am I?” is not new. Human beings have asked it for thousands of years. Yet, in the life of every sincere seeker, it feels new, as if it has arisen for the first time.

Why? Because this is not merely a question from a book. It is the question of your own life.

As long as it remains only in the head, it may look like philosophy. But when life brings sorrow, dissatisfaction, fear, loneliness, or a deep longing to understand, the same question becomes deeply practical.

Suppose someone criticizes you. Immediately something inside feels hurt. The question arises: why did this hurt me so much? Someone respects you, and happiness arises. The question arises: why do I depend so much on respect? A relationship becomes distant, and fear appears. The question arises: what am I leaning on? One day the body becomes ill, and anxiety begins. The question arises: am I only this body?

Look carefully. Our suffering is not created only by events. Much of our suffering is created by the identity we have accepted as “I.” If I believe I am only my name, then an attack on my name will hurt me. If I believe I am only my position, then losing that position will break me. If I believe I am only the body, then every change in the body will create fear. If I believe I am made by other people’s opinions, then every praise and every criticism will shake me.

That is why “Who am I?” is not merely something to think about. It is directly connected to our daily suffering, relationships, fears, desires and insecurity.

Often we spend our whole life trying to fix problems, but we do not look at the “I” to whom the problem is happening. It is like trying to clean the dust seen in a mirror, while forgetting to clean the mirror itself. Outer situations keep changing, but if the inner “I” stands on a mistaken identity, restlessness keeps returning.

So the first step is this: do not hurry to answer. First listen to the question honestly: **Who am I?**

Common Answers and Their Limits

When someone asks, “Who are you?”, we usually give an introduction.

“My name is this.” “I am a doctor.” “I am a trader.” “I am a father.” “I am a mother.” “I am a husband.” “I am a wife.” “I am a student.” “I am successful.” “I am a failure.”

All these answers are useful in practical life. In the world we need them. A form needs a name. A workplace needs a role. A relationship needs a way of relating. There is nothing wrong with these answers.

But the spiritual question is deeper. It is not asking what society calls you. It is asking: before all these names and roles, who are you?

First, look at the name. Your name was given after birth. You did not arrive in the world and announce it yourself. Your family gave the name, society accepted it, and slowly you accepted it too. A name can even be changed. Many people change their names in life. Yet the inner sense of “I” remains. So the name may be your introduction, but you are not merely the name.

Now look at profession. Someone says, “I am a teacher.” Someone says, “I am an engineer.” Someone says, “I am a shopkeeper.” But a profession can change. A job can change. A business can change. After retirement, a position may end. Does the “I” end with it? No. So profession may be your work, but you are not merely your profession.

Now look at relationships. You may be someone’s son, daughter, parent, partner or friend. Relationships can be beautiful and necessary. But every relationship exists in reference to another person. When you say, “I am a father,” that identity exists in relation to a child. When you say, “I am a son,” that identity exists in relation to parents. Yet when you sit alone quietly, the feeling “I am” is still present. No role is being performed in that moment, and still your being remains. So relationships may be your roles, but you are not merely a role.

Now look at achievements. Sometimes success comes, sometimes failure. Sometimes people praise you, sometimes they forget you. Sometimes you feel very capable, sometimes very small. If I am made of my achievements, then with every rise and fall my being should rise and fall. But does the deeper “I” truly change with every success and failure? Or does only the state of mind change?

Think of clothes. A person wears different clothes: white, colorful, old, new, formal, simple. Clothes change, but the one wearing them remains. In the same way, name, profession, relationships and achievements are like clothes of life. Respect them. Use them. But do not mistake them for your final truth. What can change cannot be your complete reality.

I Am Not the Body - The First Step

Now we come a little closer.

Human beings often take the body itself to be “I.” This feels natural because the body seems to be with us all the time. When someone says, “I am tired,” the tiredness of the body is taken as “me.” When the body is ill, we say, “I am ill.” When the body looks attractive or unattractive, pride or inferiority may arise.

But quietly look: are you only the body?

Remember a photograph from your childhood. A small body, small fingers, a different face, a different voice, a different walk. Then adolescence came. The body changed. Then youth came. The body changed again. As age increases, the body keeps changing.

The body is constantly changing. The body that was present at the age of five is not present now. Yet when you look at that childhood photograph, you naturally say, "This is me." How?

The body changed. The face changed. The voice changed. Likes and dislikes changed. Thoughts changed. Yet a deeper sense of "I" remained.

This does not mean the body should be neglected. The body is a sacred instrument of this life. It should be cared for, kept healthy, and respected. But mistaking the instrument for the owner is confusion.

Take the example of a vehicle. You travel in a car. The car takes you from one place to another. If the car breaks down, the journey becomes difficult. So taking care of the car is necessary. But are you the car? No. The car is your vehicle. In the same way, the body is the vehicle of this life-journey. Respect it, protect it, but do not reduce yourself to it.

Take another example: a mirror. Your face appears in the mirror. If the face looks tired in the mirror, you know the mirror is only showing it. The mirror is not you. In the same way, age, illness, beauty, tiredness, strength and weakness appear through the body. But is the one who knows all this also the body?

When you say, "My body is tired," listen carefully. The sentence itself says that the body is "mine." What is "mine" cannot be exactly the same as "I." You say "my hand," "my eyes," "my face," "my body," just as you say "my house," "my book," "my clothes." The house is yours, but you are not the house. Clothes are yours, but you are not the clothes. In the same way, the body is yours; but are you the body?

This is not something to accept only with the intellect. It must be seen in your own experience.

Pause for a few moments and look at your hand. The hand is visible. Now close your eyes and feel the sensations of the body. There may be heaviness somewhere, lightness somewhere, warmth somewhere, a heartbeat somewhere. All these are appearing in experience. Now ask simply: the one who knows these sensations, is that one itself a sensation?

The body appears in experience. The body changes. The body is known. Can the knower also be only the body?

This is the first real step of the question “Who am I?” We will not jump to a final conclusion. We will not hurry. We will only see this much: the body changes, and I know the change.

Clouds in the sky keep changing. Some are white, some are dark, some fast, some soft. But the sky does not become every cloud. For now, simply see that changes happen in the body, while the sense “I am” remains present.

A Small Dream Example

At night a dream appears. In the dream you have a body. You run, fear, rejoice, meet people. At that time the dream feels real. But after waking, you see that the dream body and dream world were not permanent from the waking point of view.

This example is not to say that the waking body is just a dream in the same way. It is only to show that an experience may feel very real and still be open to inquiry. Spirituality does not ask us to believe blindly. It says: look, but look deeply.

The First Door Opens

Until now we have not said anything difficult. We have only looked at life quietly.

We saw that name can change. Profession can change. Roles in relationships can change. Achievements can change. The body has also changed from childhood until now. Yet the sense “I am” remains.

This is where the search begins.

At this point there is no need to declare, “I am this” or “I am that.” Just see that what we usually call “I” is made of many changing things. They are useful in life, but they cannot be our final truth.

Let this understanding remain gentle. Do not force it. Do not turn it into a belief. Begin to see it in life.

When the body is healthy, see. When the body is tired, see. When the body looks pleasant, see. When the body feels uncomfortable, see.

Each time ask quietly: **This body is changing. Who is knowing it?**

Here the next door waits: if I am not the body, then what am I? The search now moves a little further inward, toward the mind - thoughts, emotions, memories, fears, desires

and imagination. We will examine whether I am the mind, or whether the mind too is a changing flow that is known.

Practice for Today

Today, three times during the day, pause for only thirty seconds and observe:

What is being experienced in the body right now - tiredness, lightness, tension, ease, heartbeat, or some other sensation? And the one who knows all this, is that one changing in the same way as the body?

Do not hurry to answer. Just see. This seeing is the beginning of the search.

Second Section - Am I the Mind?

From the Body to the Mind

The question still stands: **If I am not the body, then what am I?**

We saw that the body changes. The body from childhood is not the body of today, and yet the feeling “I am” has remained. But the moment a seeker hears, “I am not the body,” the mind quickly offers the next answer: “Then I must be the mind.”

This is the next inquiry. The body is visible from the outside, but the mind moves inside. Thoughts feel intimate. Emotions feel personal. Memories seem to form our story. Desires and fears seem to guide our life. So it is very natural to believe that the mind is “me.”

When we say, “I am sad,” “I am worried,” “I am thinking,” “I am happy,” it feels as if the mind itself is the self. But is that true? Is the mind our final nature, or is it also a changing flow that is known? Let us look slowly.

What Is the Mind?

No complicated psychology is needed here. In Nirvan Sutra, the mind means the inner flow of thoughts, emotions, memories, imagination, desires and fears.

Sometimes the mind worries about the future. Sometimes it repeats the past. Sometimes it is hurt by someone's words. Sometimes it searches for pleasure in imagination. Sometimes it wants to gain something. Sometimes it is afraid of losing something. All of this together is the movement of the mind.

The mind is like a river. The water in a river is never exactly the same from one moment to the next, yet we call it one river. The mind is similar. Thoughts change, emotions change, desires change, fears change, yet we say, "my mind."

Even the phrase "my mind" is a quiet hint. We say "my mind" just as we say "my house," "my phone," "my book." This does not mean the mind is useless. The mind is very useful. Through the mind we learn, plan, understand language, relate, choose and remember. But a useful instrument is not necessarily the final self.

Mind is an instrument. Mind is a field of experience. Mind is a changing flow. But am I the mind? Do not answer too quickly. Look in your own experience.

How Much the Mind Changes

Look at one ordinary day.

You wake up in the morning. If sleep was good, the mind feels light. It says, "Today I can do many things." Then a message appears on the phone, and worry arises. After a while tea is served, the weather feels pleasant, and the mind becomes fine again.

By afternoon, work pressure comes. The mind becomes tired. Someone speaks in a sharp tone, irritation arises. Then an old friend sends a message, and the mind becomes happy. In the evening an old memory comes, and sadness appears. At night a good idea comes, and the mind feels hopeful.

In one day, the mind changed so many times.

There was enthusiasm. Then worry. Then ease. Then irritation. Then happiness. Then sadness. Then hope.

Now ask quietly: if I am the mind, how many times did I change in one day?

When the mind was happy, was I only happiness? When the mind became sad, did I completely become sadness? When anger was present, was my whole existence anger? When peace returned, did I get created again?

No. Something knows all these changes.

The mind is like weather. Sometimes sunlight, sometimes clouds, sometimes strong wind, sometimes rain. Weather changes, but a person inside the house can notice it: “It is raining outside,” or “The sun is bright today.” In the same way, from within, there is a place from where we can say, “The mind is heavy today,” “The mind is quiet now,” “Fear is arising in the mind.”

Listen to this sentence carefully: **There is fear in my mind.** If fear itself were “I,” how could I know that fear is present? If thought itself were “I,” how could I say that thoughts are moving? If the mind itself were the final “I,” who would know the changes of the mind?

Here the inquiry becomes deeper.

Who Sees the Thoughts?

Now look at thoughts.

A thought says, “I should do this.” Another says, “No, it is difficult.” A third says, “What if I fail?” A fourth says, “Maybe everything will be fine.” A whole meeting seems to be going on inside the mind. One thought speaks, then another. We usually catch one thought and believe it to be true. Then we flow with it.

But have you ever simply watched a thought appear?

Think of a road. Cars, buses, bikes and people pass by. If you jump into every vehicle, you will be carried away. But if you stand by the side of the road, you can see them coming and going. Thoughts are like that. One thought comes, stays for a while, then another comes. You do not have to sit inside every thought.

Here we gently introduce the word **witness**. Witness means the quiet knowing presence that sees. Do not make it a theory yet. Just notice in experience that a thought is being known. If a thought is being known, the knower cannot be only that thought.

What is seen cannot be the seer in the same moment. Thoughts are seen. Thoughts change. Thoughts come and go. So can I be merely a thought?

This inquiry is not meant to stop the mind or fight thoughts. It is meant only to see that thoughts arise and pass, and there is a quiet knowing of their movement.

A film plays on a screen. Sometimes there is a battle, sometimes love, sometimes sorrow, sometimes laughter, darkness and light. Scenes keep changing, but the screen remains in its place. Scenes appear on the screen; the screen does not become the scenes. In the same way, the film of thoughts runs in the mind. Usually we get lost in the

film. The beginning of practice is to see the film as a film, even for a moment.

A Simple Exercise: Watching One Thought

Pause for one minute.

Sit comfortably. No special posture is necessary. Let the body be natural. You may close the eyes or keep them open.

Do not try to stop the mind. Do not try to remove thoughts. Do not try to create a special spiritual experience.

Simply wait.

Some thought will appear. Perhaps the thought, "Am I doing this correctly?" Perhaps some work will be remembered. Perhaps a person will come to mind. Perhaps the thought will come, "Nothing is happening."

Whatever thought appears, do not hold it. Do not push it away. Just notice inwardly: **A thought has appeared.**

When it passes, notice: **The thought has passed.**

If another thought comes, see again: **Another thought has appeared.**

This exercise is simple, but it is deep. You do not have to defeat thoughts. You only have to see that thoughts come by themselves and go by themselves. They can be known.

Like a person sitting at a railway station, you can watch trains arrive and leave. It is not necessary to board every train. In the same way, every thought is not your command, not your identity, not your truth. It is only a movement in the mind.

This seeing creates a little distance from the mind. This distance is not escape. It is clarity.

Examining Emotions

Now look at emotions.

Like thoughts, emotions also come and go, but they often feel stronger. A thought may be light, while an emotion may fill the body and mind. When anger comes, it feels as if I am anger. When fear comes, it feels as if I am fear. When sorrow comes, it feels as if I am made of sorrow. When joy comes, it feels as if this alone is me.

But look patiently.

Anger came, and after some time it reduced. Fear arose, and slowly changed. Sorrow felt heavy, and one day became lighter. Happiness came, and it too passed.

Emotions are real as experiences. Do not deny them. If sorrow is present, do not suppress it. If fear is present, do not pretend it is not there. If anger is present, do not hide it under a holy name. Practice means honesty.

But honesty also means seeing that an emotion came; it is not permanent.

You have lived through countless emotions: childhood fears, youthful desires, old hurts, old joys, passing anxieties. They came and went. If all of them were truly you, then when they left, you should have disappeared. But you remained.

Notice the difference between two sentences: "I am sad" and "Sadness is being experienced." In the first, identity becomes tight. In the second, a space of seeing opens.

This does not make you insensitive. Sorrow can be seen with tenderness. Fear can be seen with care. Anger can be seen without instantly following it. This is the beginning of practice.

Emotions are like waves in the ocean. A wave rises, spreads, and settles. The wave is not denied, but it is not

the whole ocean. In the same way, an emotion appears in experience, but it cannot be your complete truth.

When an emotion arises, do not immediately say, "This is me." Gently see: "This emotion is arising." Then ask: "The one who knows it - does that one rise and fall in the same way?"

Do Not Make the Mind an Enemy

One thing is important here: do not make the mind your enemy. To hate the mind is not practice. The mind is necessary for life. Through the mind we understand language, learn, work, plan, and relate with sensitivity.

The problem is not the mind. The problem is mistaking the mind for "I."

A mobile phone is useful. It helps in communication, work and information. But if a person becomes so lost in the phone that they forget the world around them, the problem is not the phone; the problem is identification and absorption.

The mind is similar. Use the mind, but do not be lost in it. Use thoughts, but do not make them your identity. Respect emotions, but do not make them your final truth.

Slowly the seeker begins to understand: the mind changes, and I can know its changes. This understanding is not the final realization, but it is the right direction.

The Second Door

First we looked at the body. The body changes. Now we have looked at the mind. The mind also changes.

Thoughts come and go. Emotions arise and settle. Memories appear, imagination forms, desires change, fears change. The weather of the mind changes every day, every hour, sometimes every minute.

Still, something knows all this.

When the body was tired, it was known. When the body was light, it was known. When thoughts came, they were known. When thoughts went, that too was known. When sorrow came, it was known. When happiness came, it was also known.

So the question becomes deeper: **If I am not the body, and not the mind, then what is it that knows both?**

This is where the next step begins. We will look more clearly at this knowing presence. We will also examine the “I” that says, “I am thinking,” “I am doing,” “I am

experiencing.” From there, the distinction between witness and experiencer will begin to open.

Practice for Today

Today, whenever a sharp thought or emotion arises - worry, anger, fear, sadness or hurry - do not immediately try to stop it.

Pause for twenty seconds and say inwardly:

This thought is arising.

This emotion is arising.

Then ask quietly: **The one who knows this, is that one changing exactly like this thought or emotion?**

Do not hurry to answer. Just see. Thoughts and emotions come and go. The seeing remains.

Third Section - The Difference Between Witness and Experienter

Turning Toward the Knower

Now the question is before us: **If I am not the body and not the mind, then what is it that knows both?**

The body is known. The mind is known. Thoughts are known. Emotions are known. Even the feeling, “I am experiencing this,” can be noticed. So the search now turns directly toward the knower.

This step is the heart of the first chapter. We will keep the language simple, but the clarity must be sharp. Nothing has to be imagined. We are only going to look at what is already present in experience.

What Is the Witness?

In Nirvan Sutra, the quiet knowing presence is called the **witness**.

The witness knows the body. The witness knows the mind. The witness knows thoughts as they come and go. The

witness knows happiness, sorrow, fear, anger, desire and confusion.

But the witness itself does not change with them.

When tiredness is present in the body, tiredness is known. When ease is present, ease is known. When happiness is present in the mind, happiness is known. When sadness is present, sadness is known. Tiredness changed. Ease changed. Happiness changed. Sadness changed. Yet the knowing presence remained.

The witness does not do anything. It simply knows.

The witness does not stop thoughts. It does not suppress emotions. It does not abandon the body. It does not run away from the world. It simply knows that all this is being experienced.

A common misunderstanding is that becoming the witness means becoming silent like a stone, having no feeling, no thought, and no involvement with life. This is not what is meant here.

Witnessing does not mean life stops. It means life continues, while inwardly there is clarity that I am not lost in the changing experiences.

Thoughts may come. Emotions may arise. The body may work. Relationships may continue. Conversation may happen. But inwardly a quiet knowing remains. This is the first recognition of the witness.

The Experienter

Now we must understand a very important difference. The witness and the experienter are not the same.

The **experienter** is the personal center that arises at the level of experience, where an experience takes the language of “my experience.” When there is pain in the body, in practical life one has to say, “I have pain.” When sorrow arises in the mind, one says, “I feel sorrow.” When peace comes in meditation, one says, “I experienced peace.”

Do not immediately judge the experienter as ego. The experienter is useful in ordinary life. Communication, healing, learning, relationships, and practice all use the language of the experienter. The problem is not that the experienter appears.

The problem begins when the experienter creates a hard identity out of an experience. “I felt sorrow” becomes “I am sorrow itself.” “I succeeded” becomes “I am superior.”

“I experienced peace” becomes “I have awakened.” This is where the layer of ego joins.

The witness knows all of this. The witness knows: sorrow is being experienced. Anger is arising. Praise has made the mind happy. Criticism has brought hurt in the mind. The witness knows the experience, but does not create a hard identity out of it.

So keep this distinction very clear in this chapter:

The experiencer is the center of experience.

Ego is the hard identity built out of experience.

The witness is the quiet presence that knows both.

This difference is subtle, but it is also very practical. When this becomes clear, the direction of practice changes.

Example One: The Pond and the Ripples

Imagine a quiet pond.

The water is still. Then a small stone falls into it. Ripples arise. They spread across the surface. For some time the water moves. Then slowly it becomes quiet again.

Now look within.

Someone speaks harshly. A stone has fallen into the mind. Ripples rise: hurt, anger, self-defense, the urge to answer, the thought “How could they say this to me?”

The experiencer immediately says, “I am hurt. They did this to me. I have been insulted.”

The witness sees, “A ripple of hurt is rising in the mind. There is tightness in the body. Thoughts want to respond. Sorrow is being experienced.”

The event is the same. The ripples are the same. The movement in the mind is the same. But the experiencer identifies with the ripples, while the witness knows the ripples.

This does not mean ripples are bad. It does not mean life should never create ripples. Events will happen. People will speak. Situations will change. Reactions will arise in the mind.

Practice is not fighting with the ripples. Practice is seeing that a ripple is rising, but I am not merely the ripple.

A ripple rises in the pond, but the depth of the water is not destroyed. In the same way, sorrow or anger may arise in the mind, but the quiet knowing presence is not destroyed.

Example Two: The Letter and the Reader

Suppose you receive several letters.

One letter contains praise. As you read it, the mind becomes happy. Another contains criticism. The mind becomes heavy. A third brings worrying news. Fear arises. A fourth brings good news. Excitement appears.

The letters changed. Their words changed. The mind's reactions changed too.

But the reader knew each letter.

The experiencer becomes completely entangled in the content of the letter. In praise, it expands. In criticism, it collapses. In fear, it trembles. In good news, it jumps.

The witness knows the reading of the letter and also knows the reaction of the mind.

It knows: praise brought happiness in the mind. Criticism brought contraction. Worrying news brought tension in the body. Good news brought joy.

Again, nothing is denied. The reaction is not suppressed. Only the identity becomes clear.

The experiencer says, "I am this reaction." The witness knows, "This reaction is appearing in experience." This is the difference that opens inner freedom.

The Experiencer Is Not Bad

Be careful here. Do not label the experiencer as bad. Do not start fighting with it. Do not try to suppress it. The experiencer is part of the personal language of practical life. It is the "I" that says, "I experienced this," "I learned this," "I feel sorrow," "I need help."

In ordinary life this is necessary. If the body needs treatment, one has to say, "I have pain." If there is sorrow in the mind, one has to say, "I feel sorrow." If something becomes clear in practice, one may say, "I had a glimpse of understanding." There is nothing wrong in this.

The purpose of practice is not to wage war against the experiencer. The purpose is simply to see that the experiencer is not the final truth. And when the experiencer makes a hard identity out of an experience, the layer of ego joins.

As witnessing becomes clearer, the seeker can see the experiencer too. You can notice: "The 'I' that wants respect is arising." You can notice: "There is an experience of

sorrow, and the mind wants to turn it into a story.” You can notice: “Pride is arising.” You can notice: “Fear is arising.”

This seeing is gentle. There is no harshness in it. There is no judgment. There is only clarity.

A Gentle Introduction to Ego

Now one more word can be understood lightly: **ego**. In Nirvan Sutra, ego means the idea of “I” that takes body, mind, name, story, and role to be its real self.

In simple language, ego says: “I am the body.” “My thoughts are me.” “My story is me.” “My success is me.” “My wound is me.” “My experiences are me.”

Remember the difference between the experiencer and ego. The experiencer says, “I had an experience.” Ego says, “This experience is my identity.” The experiencer is a useful center in practical life. Ego is the hardened identity formed around that center.

The witness does not truly change into ego. The witness is the unmoving knowing presence. But in the mind a mistaken identity appears: “I am the body-mind.” From this mistaken identity the layers of ego are formed, and the experiencer begins to cling more strongly to experiences.

We do not need to go deeply into ego here. Later chapters will examine it more fully. For now, it is enough to see that the experiencer is not to be treated as an enemy, the grip of ego has to be seen, and the witness is the quiet knowing presence before both.

A Practical Exercise: Look at a Recent Event

Now do a simple self-observation. This is not a sitting meditation. It is a way to look clearly at your life.

Remember a small event from today or yesterday. Perhaps someone did not listen to you. Perhaps someone praised you. Perhaps someone corrected you. Perhaps there was a small inconvenience at home. Perhaps a message on the phone changed your mood.

Now look at the event with three questions:

First: what happened in the body at that time? Maybe the face became warm, the chest tightened, the breath became fast, or the body felt light.

Second: what thoughts and emotions appeared in the mind? Anger, sorrow, fear, pride, happiness, or something else?

Third: at that time, was I fully entangled as the experiencer, or was there even a small amount of seeing that all this was happening within me?

Do not blame yourself. If you were completely entangled, that is fine. Seeing it now is already the beginning.

Practice does not mean that reactions never arise. Practice means that after a reaction arises, one day you can see it. Slowly you may see it while it is arising. Slowly, a small pause may appear even before the reaction takes over.

That pause is a doorway to witnessing.

Witnessing in Daily Life

Witnessing is not a mysterious experience. It is not something that requires mountains or caves. It is already present in ordinary life, but usually unnoticed.

When someone says something harsh and you pause for one moment instead of immediately reacting, a glimpse of witnessing is present.

When the day is crowded, work is heavy, people are talking, and yet somewhere inside there is a small quiet corner, that is a glimpse of witnessing.

When sorrow is present but you can see, "Sorrow is arising," that is a glimpse of witnessing.

When joy comes and you are able to experience it without the desperate need to hold it, that too is a glimpse of witnessing.

When a mistake happens and instead of drowning in guilt you can see clearly, "This mistake happened; I need to learn from it," the beginning of witnessing is there.

Witnessing does not distance you from life. It makes life clearer.

The experiencer becomes entangled in life. The witness knows life. The experiencer builds identity from every event. The witness sees each event come and go. The experiencer says, "I am broken." The witness knows, "The experience of being broken is arising." The experiencer says, "I am great." The witness knows, "Pride is arising."

This difference seems small, but it changes life deeply. The moment an experience is seen as an experience, the grip formed by it begins to loosen.

Do Not Turn Witnessing into a Special Experience

Sometimes in meditation or a quiet moment the seeker has a pleasant experience. The mind becomes silent, the body feels light, and joy or spaciousness is felt. Then the seeker says, "I experienced the witness."

This is understandable in the beginning, but a careful distinction is needed. Whatever came and went is also an experience. The witness is that which knows even that experience.

Peace came; it was known. Joy came; it was known. Emptiness came; it was known. A deep experience came; it was known.

So do not bind the witness to any special experience. The witness is not a shining event. It is the knowing in which every event is known.

The mind wants to make it special. The mind says, "I should have a great experience." The experiencer says, "I should attain knowledge." But the witness is already knowing even this desire.

So walk slowly. Do not run after special experiences. For now, simply see: whatever the experience is, it is being known.

The Heart of the Search

So far we have seen three steps.

First, the body was examined. The body changes. Then the mind was examined. The mind changes. Now we have begun to turn toward the knowing presence that knows both body and mind.

In Nirvan Sutra, that is called the witness.

The witness is the quiet knowing presence. It knows body, mind, thoughts, emotions, happiness and sorrow. It does not change with them. It does not do; it simply knows.

And we have seen that the experiencer is different. The experiencer links itself with experiences and says, “I am sad,” “I did it,” “I was hurt,” “I had knowledge.” It owns experiences and keeps changing.

Understanding this difference is the heart of “The Search for the Self.”

For now, this understanding is only the beginning. It has to become steady in life. The old habit is strong. We repeatedly identify with body, mind and the experiencer. There is no fault in that. This is the field of practice.

Next, we will see how to carry this understanding into daily life, not only in a quiet room but while walking, speaking,

listening and working. Then the journey of this chapter will be gathered into a simple living practice.

Practice for Today

Today choose one event in which you became a little entangled - a conversation, a message, a small irritation, worry, or praise.

Write or simply notice three lines:

What was the event?

What did the experiencer say in it - “I am hurt,” “I am right,” “I need respect,” or something else?

Who is quietly knowing that whole event right now?

Do not try to make the answer beautiful. Just see honestly. This seeing itself is the practice of witnessing.

Fourth Section - Stabilizing the Understanding in Life

From Understanding to Living

We have now touched the most important movement of this first chapter. The body is known. The mind is known. The experiencer is also known. The quiet knowing presence that knows all of these is called the witness in Nirvan Sutra.

This understanding may sound simple, but remembering it in daily life takes time.

To understand is one thing. To live the understanding is another. To remember it in the middle of situations, responsibilities, criticism, tiredness, praise, fear and desire - that is practice.

Now the question is not only, "What is the witness?" The question is: when life moves in its normal rhythm, how can this understanding remain alive?

Because practice is not complete only in silence. It matures exactly where life happens - in conversation, work, family, reaction, decision, and ordinary moments.

Old Habit Is Strong - This Is Normal

First understand this with love: you will forget again and again.

Sometimes witnessing will feel clear. Then a small event will happen, and you will be pulled back into the experiencer. Someone will say something, and the mind will react. A fear will arise, and identification will return. Praise will come, and pride may appear. Criticism will come, and hurt may arise.

Later you may remember, "I wanted to observe, but I got entangled again."

At that moment, do not blame yourself.

This is not failure. It is only the return of an old habit.

For years, perhaps for the whole life, we have taken body and mind to be "I." We have taken every thought seriously. We have flowed with every emotion. We have turned every event into our personal story. The habit of the experiencer is very old.

Take a simple example. If someone has sat with a bent posture for many years, the body becomes used to it. One day the person decides to sit straight. For a few minutes they sit straight; then without noticing, the body bends

again. Does this mean the person has failed? No. The body returned to an old habit. It needs to be reminded again and again, gently.

The inner habit is similar. The mind will repeatedly form identity. The experiencer will repeatedly arise. Ego will say, "I am this body-mind." Events will pull you.

But now there is a difference: you have received the direction of seeing.

Earlier you were entangled and remained entangled. Now you may become entangled, but sometimes you will also see that entanglement is happening. This is a great change.

Practice does not need harshness. It needs love, patience and honesty. Forgotten? Remember again. Entangled? See again. Reacted? Later, look at it quietly. This is the path.

Simple Ways to Remember Witnessing

No heavy discipline is needed in the beginning. Small reminders are enough. Do not make them rigid rules. Do not make them a burden. Treat them as small doors through which you return inward.

1. Pause a few times in the day. Two or three times a day, pause for a few moments and ask: "Am I entangled as

the experiencer right now, or am I seeing like the witness?" If the answer is, "I am entangled," that is also fine. Seeing the entanglement is already the beginning of witnessing.

2. One breath before a sharp reaction. When something hurts, when anger rises, when there is a hurry to reply, take one breath. Just one breath. Breath came in. Breath went out. In that small pause you may notice: "The mind wants to react." "The body is tight." "The experiencer is feeling hurt." This does not mean you must remain silent. You may still speak, but speaking from even a little clarity is different from blind reaction.

3. Two minutes at the end of the day. Before sleep, sit for two minutes. Do not analyze the whole day. Just remember: where did I become completely entangled today? Where did I get a glimpse of witnessing? At what moment did I see the body or mind as an experience? This is not for blaming yourself. It is to gently strengthen the power of seeing.

4. Name the emotion without turning it into identity. When an emotion arises, do not immediately say, "I am this." Say gently, "Anger is arising." "Fear is arising." "Sadness is being experienced." "There is restlessness in the mind." "There is tension in the body."

This small shift is useful. “I am sad” strengthens identity. “Sadness is being experienced” opens the space of seeing.

This is not merely a play of language. It changes the direction of identification. Slowly the mind begins to understand that every emotion is not the final truth. It comes, stays for a while, and passes. It can be known.

A Summary of the Whole Journey

Let us gather the thread of this first chapter.

In the beginning, we examined the body. We saw that the body has changed from childhood until now. The body is an instrument of life, but taking the body to be the final “I” is incomplete.

Then we examined the mind. Thoughts, emotions, memories, desires and fears make up the flow of the mind. The mind is useful, but it also changes every day. So the mind too cannot be the permanent “I.”

Then we looked at the difference between witness and experiencer. The experiencer gets linked with experiences and says, “I am sad,” “I did it,” “I was hurt,” “I had knowledge.” The witness simply knows that experience is happening. It knows body, mind, thought, emotion, happiness and sorrow, but does not change with them.

This is the basic direction of the chapter:

The body changes.

The mind changes.

The experiencer attaches itself to experiences.

The witness knows.

The search for the Self begins by returning to this witnessing.

What Comes Next in the Nirvan Sutra?

“The Search for the Self” is the first chapter of Nirvan Sutra. Its work is to turn the seeker from outer identity toward inner inquiry. You have now begun to see that body and mind can be known, and that the direction of witnessing is possible.

The coming chapters will deepen this foundation.

One chapter will examine Maya and the world: why the world appears so solid, and yet why it is not the final truth.

Another will expand the witness-attitude, not only as an idea but as living awareness in the middle of life.

Another will examine the layers of ego: how the “I” forms around body, mind, story, achievement, wound and experience.

The complete Nirvan Sutra Nirvan Sutra contains eight chapters. Each chapter is a step. No step is higher or lower in a competitive sense. Each is needed. A slow walk makes the foundation strong.

After completing all eight chapters, there will be an online examination. This examination is not meant to frighten the seeker. It is not a school-like pressure where one must prove superiority. It is more like the next doorway.

It helps see whether the seeker has only read the teachings, or has begun to look at them in their own experience. The review will be done by the Guru himself. This review is not to stop the seeker, but to help them move in the right direction.

After passing the examination, the seeker will enter the private group of Nirvan Dham. There, the journey will not remain solitary. With guidance, dialogue and the presence of other sincere seekers, this understanding can become steadier in life.

So do not look at the examination as a barrier. See it as a welcoming door. It asks only for honesty.

Walk Slowly, Walk Truly

There is no place for hurry on this path.

The mind wants a quick answer. The experiencer wants quick achievement. Ego wants to declare quickly, "I have understood." But in the search for the Self, hurry often keeps us on the surface.

Walk slowly.

See one thing at a time. See the body. See the mind. See emotions. See reactions. See the experiencer. Return again and again to the quiet knowing presence.

This returning is the practice.

Some days you may feel clear. Some days you may feel as if everything is forgotten. Sometimes the mind will be peaceful. Sometimes it will be very disturbed. All of this is part of the journey. Do not make any of it the final judgment.

The real learning is to bring what you have read into life.

When someone does not understand you, see. When someone praises you, see. When the body is tired, see. When the mind is restless, see. When there is peace inside, see that too.

The witness is not recognized only in difficulty. It is also recognized in happiness.

A Final Blessing

Dear seeker, in this first chapter you have taken an important step.

You have begun turning from outer identity toward inner inquiry. This is not a small step. Many people spend their whole life in name, work, relationships, success, failure and the stories of the mind. But when the question “Who am I?” rises honestly, the direction of life begins to change.

Keep this question close.

Do not leave it only on the pages of a book. Carry it into your day, into your relationships, into your reactions, into your silence, into your tiredness and into your joy.

This is not a race. It is not a performance. It is not a journey of collecting spiritual achievements.

It is a return to yourself.

To walk slowly is to walk rightly. To see honestly is practice. To forget and return again is progress.

The quiet knowing presence within you has not gone anywhere. Attention was simply entangled outside. Now, slowly, attention is returning.

The journey will continue. In the next chapter of Nirvan Sutra, we will take this understanding toward the world, Maya and appearance. We will see how what looks so solid outside is connected with inner identity.

For now, complete this first chapter with love. Do not try to prove what you have understood. Allow it to be seen in life in the coming days.

This is enough. This is the beginning. This is the doorway.

Practice for This Week

For the next seven days, keep one light practice.

Three times a day, pause and ask:

What am I identifying with right now - body, mind, experiencer, or am I able to see like the witness?

At night, before sleep, remember for two minutes:

Where did I get entangled today?

Where did I receive a small glimpse of seeing?

At what moment did I see an experience as an experience, and not as my final self?

Do not make this a rule. Do not make it a burden. Let it be a loving invitation to return within.

This is the practice of the first chapter. This is the preparation for the next step.